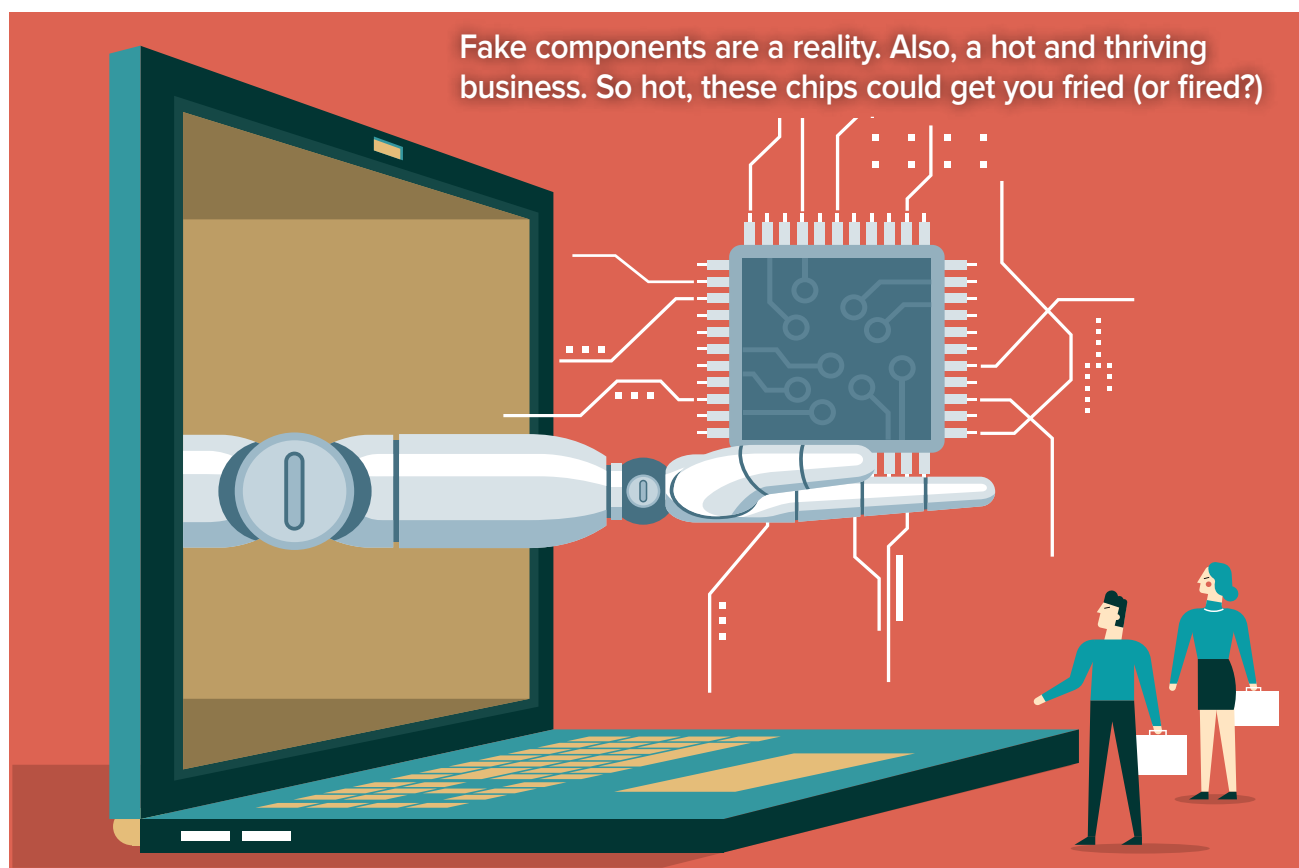




Fake Chips: Should Engineers Worry?



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The global semiconductor shortage is dragging down phone makers and auto makers, and almost everyone in the electronics industry. In this backdrop, fakes thrive.

Thrive, where o' where? Fortunately, not in the inventories of brand-name component distributors you trust (dwindling as their inventories are). For first-hand knowledge, just visit your favourite and trusted component distributor's web page. For example, Mouser, Digikey, Element-14, or R.S. Components (in no particular order). Now type in a search for your favourite microcontroller family, say

STM32F07 to name one. When I tried that, out of the 75 different parts that turned up, only one part number showed up as in stock! The other 74 entries showed zero stock.

Head over to AliExpress, an online marketplace operated by China based Alibaba Group Holding Ltd. Here you can find a great number of vendors selling all sorts of wares. Type in a search for STM32F072, and you will see quite a few listings worded 'New Original,' '100 % Quality,' etc. Prices may not be dirt-cheap but well. (Acquired wisdoms of supply and demand step in to restore your faith.)

And, if your product needed that chip, and